

A Christmas Fantasy

A Christmas Fantasy

The Project Gutenberg eBook of The escape of Alice: A Christmas fantasy

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: The escape of Alice: A Christmas fantasy

Author: Vincent Starrett

Release date: December 22, 2022 [eBook #69601]

Most recently updated: October 19, 2024

Language: English

Original publication: United States: Torch Press, 1919

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/69601

Credits: Charlene Taylor, Donald Cummings and the Online Distributed Proofreading Team at <https://www.pgdp.net>
(This file was produced from images generously made available by The Internet Archive/American Libraries.)

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE ESCAPE
OF ALICE: A CHRISTMAS FANTASY ***

A Christmas Fantasy

A Christmas Fantasy

The Escape of Alice

A Christmas Fantasy

By

Vincent Starrett



PRIVATELY PRINTED AT
CEDAR RAPIDS IOWA FOR
THE FRIENDS OF LUTHER
ALBERTUS AND ELINORE
TAYLOR BREWER CHRISTMAS
NINETEEN NINETEEN

Copyright 1919
By Vincent Starrett

TO OUR FRIENDS

It has been well said, that a friend in need is a friend indeed.

Such a friend, Vincent Starrett, of Chicago, has proven to be to us.

Last year, more to our regret than to the regret of our friends, we were compelled reluctantly to forego the pleasure and privilege of holding a session with them around our fireplace or beneath our reading lamp.

And a similar situation was imminent at this Christmas time—when our good fairy, Mr. Starrett, one morning dropped on our desk *The Escape of Alice* with the cheerful message, “It is yours, Brewer, for your Christmas booklet, if you want it.”

So here it is—a pleasant Christmas fantasy—sent to our friends of old and to some new ones, with all the best greetings of the season.

THE BREWERS

December 25 1919

THE ESCAPE OF ALICE

The red linen covers opened slightly, and a little girl slipped out, leaving behind her a curious vacancy in one of the familiar pictures signed with Mr. Tenniel's initials. She looked about her with bright, alert eyes, hoping no one had been a witness to her desertion, and then carefully began to climb down. She need not have alarmed herself, for she was no bigger than a minute, and clearer eyes than those of the rheumatic old antiquarian who kept the shop would have been needed to comprehend her departure. Fortunately, the shelf onto which she had emerged was not high, and by exercising great caution the little girl was able to reach the floor without mishap.

Still watching the old man closely, she reached a hand into the pocket of her print dress and produced a few crumbs of cake, which she immediately ate. Almost instantly she began to grow, and, in a moment, from a tiny little mite of three or four inches, she had shot up into as tall a schoolgirl of thirteen as the proudest parent could wish. The ascent, indeed, was so rapid that before she quite realized what had happened, there was her head on a level with the shelf upon which, only an instant before, she had been standing; and there was the prison from which she had escaped. "Alice's Adventures in Wonderland," read the gold letters over the door.

She plucked the volume from its place, and advanced with it toward the guardian of the bookshop.

"If it is not too high," said Alice, "I think I shall take this."

The old bookseller, whose wits had been woolgathering for many years, would not have admitted for worlds that he had not heard her enter the shop. He took the book from her hand.

"You choose wisely," he said, and patted the red covers lovingly. "Alice—the ageless child! It is one of the greatest compendiums of wit and sense in literature. There are only two books to match it. You shall have it for fifteen cents, for it is far from new, and I see what I had not noticed before, that the frontispiece is missing."

“And what are the other two?” asked Alice, eagerly.

“When you are older you will read them,” said the old bookman. “They are called ‘Don Quixote’ and ‘The Pickwick Papers’.”

Then very suddenly Alice blushed, for she remembered that she could not pay. Timidly, she handed back the red-covered volume.

“I am sorry,” she said, “but I have no money. I don’t know why I was so stupid as to come away without any.”

“Money!” cried the antiquarian. “Did I ask you money for this book? Forgive me! It is a habit I have fallen into for which I am very sorry. Money is the least important thing in the world. Only the worthless things are to be had for money. Those things which are beyond price—thank God!—are to be had for the asking. Take it, child! Tomorrow is Christmas day. I should be grieved indeed if there were no *Alice* for you on Christmas day—as grieved as if there were no Santa Claus.”

There was something so unearthly about this strange old man that Alice wondered if she were not yet in Wonderland. With a sobriety quite out of keeping with her usually merry disposition, she thanked him and went forth into the snow-clad streets.

The plethora of Santa Clauses spending the holiday week-end in the city bewildered Alice, and now, after a long afternoon in the hurly-burly of metropolitan life, she was becoming tired. The number of Santa Clauses resident upon earth appalled her, and the extravagance of their promises, while pleasant enough, almost frightened her. Without any questions asked—even her address, which, had it been requested, would have taxed her wits rather severely—they accepted her commissions and guaranteed immediate delivery. The final excursion through the great department stores had been adventurous and diverting, but now—toward nightfall—was becoming monotonous, what with its profusion of Kris Kringles and street hawkers, and its babble of eleventh hour shoppers. It was like witnessing a really thrilling movie drama for the second time, thought Alice, who had initiated herself into the delights of moving-picture entertainment for the first time that day, and wondered at its remarkable duplication. By five o’clock the little girl knew just what each and every Santa Claus was going

to say to her, and what was coming next, and that one—at least—of the three remaining Santas would want to kiss her. She had been kissed almost to death, as it was, and that was beginning to bore her, too.

It occurred to Alice, who was a shrewd little girl and not one of your bleating lambs, that Santa Claus, despite his profusion—or because of it—might be something of an old fraud, after all. She was entirely certain that not one of him resembled the jolly old saint of her mental picture. The cottony fellow at Wanacooper's was not a bit red and chubby, nor very jovial either; and she hoped that the others—at the Emporium, and the Bargain Store, and the Bon Marché—would agree more sympathetically, as to corpulence, with the merry and very dear old gentleman of her favorite poem.

She repeated the first lines, softly, under her breath:

*'Twas the night before Christmas,
And all through the house
Not a creature was stirring,
Not even a mouse....*

Well, that was not not surprising. Obviously, all the creatures who might otherwise have been stirring about the house on the night before Christmas were crowding and jostling each other in department stores, buying useless presents for people they didn't like. Alice thought it odd that this hadn't occurred to her before. It made the beginning of the poem quite clear.

The Santa Claus at the Emporium was entirely surrounded by children. Entirely surrounded? Why not? The schoolroom definition of an island is authority for it: "An island is a body of land entirely surrounded by water." Sticklers for accuracy will have it that the "entirely" is extraneous. If, they say, if he—or it—that is, Santa Claus or the island—is surrounded by anything (whether water or children), he—or it—is surrounded, and that is all there is to it. Not "entirely surrounded"; just surrounded. Happily, Alice knew nothing of this. As for us, we are nothing if not independent, and care nothing for grammarians—nothing at all. The Santa Claus at the Emporium was entirely surrounded by children, just like all his duplicates, and, in the midst of an alarming racket, was writing long lists of juvenile wants in a big bookkeeper's ledger. The big bookkeeper was nowhere about, and so the

old fellow went right ahead, just as if it had been his own ledger, and filled as many columns as a child wished, in the most amiable manner in the world. He was the nicest Santa Claus Alice had yet seen.

He did not immediately notice Alice, who was neither larger nor smaller than most of the other children shouting around him; but when he did notice her he liked her right away. He liked the old-fashioned way of her, and her last century clothes, and from the way she looked at him he was sure that *she*, at least, believed in him, and wasn't dropping in just to see how much she could get out of him. And then he hurried, so that he could finish quickly with the others and get around to Alice. It wasn't very long until there she was—right up beside him, with his dear old whiskers tickling her shell-like ears (one of them, anyway), and his pen poised over a perfectly blank page, ready to write down anything that Alice asked him to. And his voice, too, was very pleasant.

“Now,” said this kindly old saint, adjusting his eyebrows with some care, for they were slightly moth-eaten and appeared to be falling off—and no wonder, either, for some hundreds of boys and girls had been leaning against them all day—“Now,” said this nice old man, “what do you wish me to bring *you* for Christmas, little Golden-hair?”

There was something charming about the way he emphasized the *you* that put Alice at ease immediately. So she told him all about the lovely doll, and the darling kitten, and the sweet bird she wanted, and had been wanting for a long time, and all about the books she needed with which to catch up on the world. For she had been locked away for so long that she felt a bit out of date, and such phrases as “League of Nations” and “Maple Nut Sundae” simply meant nothing to her, while they were the common property of every other girl and boy in the land.

The good-natured old soul wrote them all down very carefully, and then kissed Alice just as she had expected he would. He promised faithfully to deliver every one of her orders, in person, and warned her about seeing that the hearth fire was extinguished before midnight.

“Because promptly at midnight,” he said, “I shall come down the chimley.”

Alice giggled at that.

“You mean the chimney, don’t you?” she asked.

“Chimney, indeed!” snorted Santa Claus. “After all these years, don’t you think I know the difference between a chimney and a chimley? No, sir! I come down a chimley, every time. I’ll leave it to everyone here.”

And turning to the crowd of boys and girls around him, he asked: “How do I get into the house, children?”

“Down the chimley!” roared the chorus.

“You see?” said Santa Claus.

Alice did see, and felt very much ashamed of her display of ignorance.

“Never mind,” said Santa Claus, kindly. “But I think,” he added, “you had better go with my assistant, and be quite sure we have all these things in stock. He’ll be glad to show you around. It’s all free, you know. Just look around as long as you like, and if you see anything else you want, come right back and tell me about it.”

There was a little boy standing beside Santa Claus, with a metal tag on his collar, and the generous old gentleman turned to him and told him to go and fetch his—that is, Santa Claus’s—assistant. While Alice was waiting, a lot of other children pushed forward, and Alice was pretty nearly forgotten. But after a while she heard some one say, “He’s coming now. He’ll be here in just a minute, now,” and at the same moment she saw Santa Claus’s assistant coming toward her.

He was a sprightly little fellow, and Alice decided to like him. He came up in a sort of blue-green light, which danced all around him, and without the slightest hesitation Alice took his hand and walked away with him.

The little man’s fingers were so cold and hard, though, that Alice was surprised, and when she was sure he wasn’t looking she looked him over earnestly. After she had done that, she almost screamed, used as she was to odd things in Wonderland. For the little man was made of wood. Everything was wood, and Alice was holding on to his wooden fingers, and he was talking out of his wooden mouth, and the whole affair was the most wooden episode Alice could remember. His remarks concerning some of the books Alice wanted, the little girl thought, were the most wooden thing about him.

But the little man's face was rather nice, for it was highly painted in blue and green, and he had bright yellow eyes that fairly sparkled with enamel.

"Let's see," said the wooden man. "Dolls were first on the list, weren't they? Well, here we are. We call this room 'The Kingdom of Dolls,' although as a matter of fact it is ruled by a Queen, and never did have a King, because the Queen is rather old and nobody will marry her. And as she won't allow any of the other dolls to marry until she herself finds a King, it makes it hard for the younger ones."

"Dear me," said Alice. "Do you suppose I might get a peep at the Queen, without being seen?"

"Easy enough," said the wooden man, "for there she is—that long-haired doll with the purple robe. She likes to be looked at, and I need hardly remark that her hair is false. She's awfully stuck up, though, and we won't tarry long, for she'd only snub us."

"What a funny crown she is wearing," laughed Alice, turning her head to look back.

"You may well say so," said the wooden man, ironically, "for it is made of kistletoe. She never takes it off!"

"Kistletoe!" said Alice, and then, forgetting her humiliating experience about the chimley, "Don't you mean mistletoe?"

"No, I mean kistletoe," replied the wooden man, rather impatiently. "Everybody knows what kistletoe is. But then, perhaps you are too young. When you are older you will know more."

"I'm thirteen," said Alice, with proper dignity.

"Thirteen!" shrieked the wooden man, so loudly that Alice felt sure she had offended again. "What a dreadfully unlucky number! I should be frightened to death to be thirteen. How long have you been thirteen?"

"Nearly two months now," Alice confessed, miserably. Then she brightened. "But everybody has to be thirteen sometime. Weren't you ever thirteen?"

"Never!" declared the wooden man, firmly. "When my thirteenth birthday approached, I tore off an entire year of the calendar, and passed

right into my fourteenth year. Of course, there was a fearful row about it! But it's really just like skipping a grade at school. If you're smart enough you can do it. We have some very nice calendars," he added, professionally.

Alice was frankly bewildered, but she had forgotten her wounded dignity. In a moment her attention was attracted by a succession of melodious sounds, ending on a queer upward inflection that seemed to leave the phrase unfinished, and hanging in the air.

"Do listen!" she exclaimed. "Isn't that too sweet? It sounds like a bird singing."

"Most birds do," said the wooden man, drily. "That's your bird," he added, more politely. "You asked for a bird, you know."

"But why does it end its song so abruptly?" asked Alice. "It doesn't seem to finish."

"Confinement," answered the little guide, briefly. "Its cage is too small. Its notes only reach the top of the cage, and then echo back into its own ears, which naturally surprises it into silence. It's too bad, for it's losing its upper register. It once sang very well."

"I shall let it go when I get it," declared Alice, with decision.

"You may do as you please, of course," agreed the wooden man, "but you'll only be wanting another one, next Christmas."

They hurried forward, pressing through the crowd about the cage. It was humorous the way the people fell back on either side of the wooden man's sharp-elbows. What they saw, when they reached the cage, was a beautiful yellow bird with black wings, and big black eyes, swinging and singing on a perch of gold.

"Wound up too tightly," muttered the wooden man. "One of the monkeys has been monkeying with the key."

With a ferocious glare at the children around him, he reached in a hand, and Alice heard a sharp click. The bird stopped singing in the middle of a note. Then the wooden man lifted the little creature from its perch and brought it forth with as little concern as if it were made of wood, too.

“Oh!” cried Alice, in distress. “You mustn’t hurt the bird! It wasn’t its fault that somebody monkeyed with the key.”

The word *monkeyed* puzzled her, but she supposed it was all right, since that was what the wooden man had said.

But the wooden man only laughed and held out the bird for her inspection. Then Alice saw that it was not a real bird at all, but was made of thin metal so skilfully painted as to look real.

“You forget this is Toyland,” grinned the wooden man. “This bird is no more real than I am, than these children are—than you are!”

“Ain’t I real?” asked Alice, in alarm. Quickly correcting herself, she said: “Am I not real?”

“Real enough,” said the wooden man, casually. “A real nuisance,” he muttered, under his breath; but fortunately Alice did not hear this rude remark. He continued, more pleasantly: “Oh, the bird is real enough, too. But it’s been wound up too tightly. It doesn’t know what it is singing, or why it is singing. It lacks a soul.”

This remark was too deep for Alice, so she made no reply. After a minute, she asked:

“Aren’t there any more animals?”

“Birds aren’t animals,” sneered the wooden man, and then he was very much ashamed of himself. “I beg your pardon,” he said, contritely. “I had forgotten you are only thirteen.” (He shuddered as he mentioned the sinister number.) “Well, yes, there is the Performing Pony, and the Whistling Toad, and the Talking Dog, and the Teddy Bear, and the Laughing Hyena, and the Sorrowful Snake, and the Ingenious Ibex, and the Loquacious Lynx, and—Oh, we have quite a menagerie!”

He looked quizzically at Alice, and suddenly began to sing:

*O, ferocious and atrocious is the beast they call the lynx;
And fierce his howl, and black his scowl, and red his jowl,
methinks....*

“You have a very nice voice,” said Alice, as the singer paused.

“I wish you wouldn’t interrupt,” snapped the wooden man. “First you want to hear about the animals, and then you don’t.” He stopped short. “Do you really like my voice?” he asked eagerly. Then his head drooped woodenly, for he saw that Alice was no longer paying attention.

“I haven’t much of a voice myself,” mused the little girl, “but I think I could speak a piece.”

“Let’s hear it,” urged the wooden man. And moment Alice heard herself reciting:

*I thought I heard a parson swear
Because his eyes were sore;
I turned around, and saw it was
The watchdog’s honest snore.
“Alas,” he whispered, tearfully,
“That two times two is four!”*

*I thought I saw a mastodon
Upon the pantry shelf;
I looked again, and saw it was
A picture of myself.
“O dear,” I said, “the albatross
Is eating all the pelf!”*

“What’s pelf?” demanded the wooden man, critically.

“Pelf is—I think it’s something to eat,” explained Alice. “But I didn’t have to say pelf, could have said elf, or delf—”

“Or skjelf!” jeered the wooden man. “Poetic license is a dangerous thing for a girl of thirteen. I shall see that yours is revoked at once.”

Alice began to cry with shame and humiliation.

“There, there,” cried the wooden man, ashamed of himself again. “I was only plaguing you. You rhyme beautifully—much better than I do. Now, let’s go and see P. D.”

“P. D.?” queried Alice, drying her tears. “Who is P. D.?”

“Why the Plausible Donkey, to be sure,” laughed the wooden man. “You said you wanted to see some more animals.”

“Why don’t you call him D. P.?” asked Alice, after a moment, as they walked toward the menagerie.

“Why?” The wooden man seemed suspicious.

“Democratic Party,” giggled Alice; and then stopped as she caught sight of the wooden man’s face, which was contorted with pain. “I beg your pardon,” she added, hastily.

But the wooden man wouldn’t speak another word until they had arrived at the Donkey Shelter, when he became cheerful once more.

“Let me introduce you to the Plausible Donkey,” he said, gallantly.

“Pleased to meet you, Mr. Donkey,” said Alice, timidly. “What beautiful eyes you have.”

“The better to see you with, my child,” quoted the Plausible Donkey, just to show that he was not such a donkey as he looked. “What can I do for you to-day?”

“Can you sing?” asked Alice, innocently.

“Heavens!” groaned the wooden man, in her ear. “Now you’ve done it! He has no more voice than a crow!”

But the Plausible Donkey was pleased by the question.

“It is not surprising that you do not know my ability in that respect,” he smiled, “since this is your first visit. The fact is—” He blushed modestly. “The fact is, I am descended from that notable singer, Maxwelton.”

“Maxwelton!” echoed Alice, in surprise. “I thought that was a song.”

“It was originally,” the Plausible Donkey said plausibly. “My ancestor was named after the song because his brays were bonnie.”

“Oh,” said Alice, politely; but the wooden man snickered and spoiled it all.

“You’re making fun of me,” she cried, with tears in her voice, “and I don’t want to hear you sing now.”

She hurried away, leaving the wooden man to apologize as best he could for Alice's impoliteness. He was puffing mightily when he overtook her.

"I think we've had enough of animals," he said between gasps. "Let's go over and see the books." It was evident, even to Alice, that he was getting tired of his charge.

They were in the book department before they knew it—before Alice knew it, at any rate. All around them were books—heaps and heaps of them—on tables and shelves, and piled on long counters, and hung up in booths; and in the very center of the immense room, whose horizon could not be seen for the stacks of books, was a great American Eagle, made entirely of books, the work of the chief window-dresser, who was a very literary man.

"Have you 'The Young Visitors'?" asked Alice.

"Young visitors!" echoed the wooden man. "Santa Claus has dozens of them—hundreds—every day. Thousands, I guess!"

"Silly! It's a book," said Alice. "It was written by a friend of mine, Daisy Ashford, when she was only nine years old."

The wooden man looked very suspiciously at his charge.

"Nobody could write a book at nine," he said with finality.

"Daisy could, and did," declared Alice.

"Nobody could get it published, anyway," sneered the wooden man. "Of course, anybody could write one."

"And she had it published, and here it is!" cried Alice, triumphantly. She snatched a book from a long counter, and presented it to her companion.

The wooden man cautiously took it, turned it over, and handed it back.

"Where does it say she is only nine years old?" he demanded.

"In the preface, of course," answered Alice. "She's older now, but she was only nine when she wrote it."

She whirled over the leaves until she found the place.

"There it is! Sir James Barrie himself says so, in the preface."

“Humph!” said the wooden man. “He probably wrote it himself. And he wasn’t nine when he wrote it, either, although he’s pretty childish, at that. He’s writing introductions, now, for anybody.”

“He would at least know how to spell visitors, wouldn’t he?”

The wooden man stared at the cover. At sight of the title he was visibly shaken.

“It might be a typographical error,” he ventured. “But, if you know this Daisy Ashford, what’s her book about?”

“It’s about a man who—who was in love with—with a young woman,” lucidly explained Alice. “He was rather an old man, and—”

“Then Barrie wrote it!” interrupted the wooden man. “That ends *that*!”

“It doesn’t end anything,” cried Alice, almost in tears. “And he doesn’t write as many introductions as H. G. Wells, anyway!”

“O-ho!” said the wooden man. “Well?”

“Wells!” said Alice, sharply. “Wells, Wells! How many wells make a river?”

“Really,” admonished the wooden man, “you mustn’t get out of temper. I don’t like Wells any more than you do. I find it difficult to get to the bottom of them....” He fell to singing:

*Mr. Britling saw it through,
That was more than I could do!
Central, ring up Heaven’s bells—
Get me God, for H. G. Wells.*

Alice appeared shocked at this levity.

“You should not be so Leviticus,” she said, “even in a good cause.”

“I don’t mean to be irrelevant,” replied the wooden man. “I was only reviewing Mr. Wells in rhyme. Would you like to hear the next verse? It’s about Amy Lowell.”

“I don’t believe I’d better,” answered Alice, nervously. “Is she anything like Daisy Ashford?”

“They’re not exactly as like as twins,” admitted the wooden man. “Your Daisy is rather—er—slender, is she not?”

“Oh, very!”

“Then she’s not,” said the wooden man, with conviction. “I have never seen Amy Lowell, but Mr. Bitter Wynner, who was here one day last week, told me that he had got up in a street car and offered to be one of three men to give Miss Lowell a seat.”

“Dear me!” exclaimed Alice. “She needs some of my cake.”

“Cake?” asked the wooden man.

But Alice, fearing she had betrayed herself, would say no more about it.

“Well,” said the wooden man, “we’ve checked on the doll, and the bird, and the books. There was to be a kitten, I believe. That means that we’ll have to go back to the menagerie.”

“I won’t go back to the menagerie,” Alice said firmly, “and if the kittens are no more polite than the donkeys, I won’t have one.”

“You’ll have to ask Santa Claus to strike it off the list then, or you’ll have it sure tomorrow morning. And we’ll have to hustle, too, for the old boy closes up at eight o’clock. He went on strike for a shorter day, last month—seven hundred of him—and after eight o’clock he won’t do a lick of work.”

“Let’s hurry,” cried Alice, breathlessly.

So they hurried back through the teeming aisles, past the Plausible Donkey, who brayed after them jeeringly, past the Singing Bird, which offered to finish its song if they would only tarry, past the stuck-up Queen of the Dolls, who ogled the Wooden Man, shamefully, and at length arrived at the cottony dwelling of Santa Claus. But—alas!—the door now was closed, and tacked to the outer panel was a large sign, “Gone to the Races. Back Next Year.”

“Oh!” said Alice, “isn’t it provoking! Now I shall have to have a kitten, after all—and I suppose it will eat the bird, and scratch the doll, and tear up the books, and make me angry all day long.”

“No doubt,” said the wooden man, callously.

“But what does he mean by the races?” asked curious Alice.

“The reindeer races,” replied the wooden man. “They race annually on Saturn’s race track, and the winning Santa Claus is the boss Santa Claus of the year, and makes the rounds on Christmas eve. It doesn’t take a minute to get there, and probably by this time the races are over.”

“I hope our Santa Claus won, don’t you?” cried Alice.

“What’s the difference?” asked the wooden man. “They all look alike.”

“That’s so,” said Alice, reflectively, “but this one was very nice.”

“They’re paid to be nice,” said the wooden man cynically. “I’m paid to be nice. You don’t think I’ve been piloting *you* round all afternoon for fun, do you?”

“Well,” said Alice, with spirit, “I like that! I’m sure if I knew who paid you, I’d report you and you wouldn’t get a penny. You don’t deserve it, for you haven’t been nice. I shall leave you, this minute.”

“Good-bye,” grinned the wooden man, mockingly. “Close the door after you as you go out.”

“That was a very rude wooden man,” thought Alice to herself, as, half blinded with tears, she hurried through the snowy streets. “It is very evident that he tore off his thirteenth year. That is the year when people learn to be polite. And he said I was not real! I never knew till I was thirteen how real I was.”

Without quite knowing where she was going, unconsciously her footsteps strayed toward the shop of the old bookman, the only friend she had found who seemed to be genuine. The precious volume, which once she had thought a prison, was safe beneath her arm. Well, she knew now what she would do. She would give it back, and if the old man were so kind as to let her, she would creep back into the pages, and be happy there again forever....

“Poor child,” smiled the old bookman, when she had related her adventures, and cried over them. “Indeed he did need his thirteenth year. That is the age at which one best appreciates what reality is. Once learned,

it is a lesson never to be forgotten. To the child of thirteen, all things are real if they are beautiful, and all things are unreal which are ugly. Anything is real that we want to be real. Sensible writers, like Barrie, learn this at thirteen and tear off *all* the remaining years of the calendar. Time passes, but they remain thirteen; they improve their style, their appreciation of beautiful things deepens, their outlook is broader and finer, but at heart they are still children. They have never escaped from their thirteenth year, and they never will—and they are very glad about it.”

To this astonishing harangue, Alice had no reply, for truth to tell she understood very little of it; but it sounded real, and she liked the look on the old bookman’s face as he said it.

“Would you mind, sir,” she timidly asked, “if I were to creep back into my book, and hide again on your shelf?”

“Are you quite sure you can manage it?” asked the old man.

“Oh, yes,” said Alice, “for I still have a piece of cake that I brought with me. I had two pieces—one to make me grow, and one to make me small again. Just watch me!”

Then she took a few crumbs of cake from her pocket and began to eat them; and the old bookman standing by, saw her shrink down and down and down, until she was such a tiny little thing at his feet that his eyes could barely find her.

He picked her up gently, and opened the book lying on the counter.

“You must find the place,” he said: “Do you remember it?”

With a little sigh of relief, Alice slipped into the right picture, where, to her great joy, she fitted like a glove—and suddenly the picture was complete again, and the old bookman turning the leaves over could not find her—there were so many of her, and he did not know which one was really *her*.

Suddenly the book fell from his hand, and clattered onto the floor, striking his foot as it fell. At the same instant, of course, he awoke, sitting in his chair near the old stove. He smiled a little, but was not surprised, for he was used to dreaming strange and pleasant dreams. As he stooped to pick up the book, a customer entered the store.

“What have you there?” asked the stranger, looking at the book in the old man’s hand. “‘Alice in Wonderland?’ Charming thing! What do you ask for it?”

“Not this copy,” said the old man, firmly. “This is my personal copy. This is one book you cannot buy.”

TWO HUNDRED COPIES OF THIS BOOK
WERE PRINTED BY THE TORCH PRESS
CEDAR RAPIDS IOWA IN THE MONTH
OF DECEMBER NINETEEN NINETEEN

Transcriber’s Notes:

Printer’s, punctuation, and spelling inaccuracies were silently corrected.

Archaic and variable spelling has been preserved.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE ESCAPE OF
ALICE: A CHRISTMAS FANTASY ***

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at www.gutenberg.org/license.

Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the

collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with

this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official

version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website (www.gutenberg.org), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, “Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation.”
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.

- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES

EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a)

distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at www.gutenberg.org.

Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact

links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at www.gutenberg.org/contact

Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit www.gutenberg.org/donate.

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: www.gutenberg.org/donate.

Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility: www.gutenberg.org.

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.